

STRATUM

THE ANSWER IS INSIDE YOU

Psychologist Carl Rogers spent decades studying what actually changes how a person thinks and behaves — and found, case after case, that it was rarely advice. Advice arrives from outside a person. It has to compete with everything they already believe about themselves. Insight arrives from inside a person. It doesn't have to compete with anything. It's already theirs.

Rogers called his approach non-directive: the practitioner doesn't hand over the answer. They ask the question that lets the other person find it on their own. It sounds almost too simple to count as a method. In practice it's one of the harder disciplines to hold onto — because the instinct, especially for anyone who already knows a great deal, is to give advice.

Ted was stuck on a scene between two old friends — one of them moving away, the last dinner before she goes. He didn't need advice or a worksheet. He needed a memory.

A THIRTY-YEAR-OLD MEMORY

He thought about Stefan — a foreign exchange student who lived with his family for a year. Months before he was scheduled to leave he began quietly pulling away from the family. This was a very emotional time for everyone with many conflicted feelings.

This memory had sat untouched for years. It prompted Ted to move from “what happens in this scene” to something more personal: How long has Zeynep been preparing herself to leave? That question didn't match anything Ted had already written down about Zeynep. It had to go somewhere else to get answered. It went to Stefan.

Ted didn't make a conscious decision that the Stefan memory would make a good parallel. The memory arrived because a question left him nowhere else to look. That's the difference between a detail you select and a detail that surfaces. One is craft. The other is retrieval.

If Ted had asked AI to write the scene or simply used a character worksheet, none of this would have happened. A generator has no access to an emotional time with an exchange student thirty years ago. It can only produce what's statistically common for a scene like this one — the kind of grief-adjacent goodbye dinner that shows up in a great deal of fiction, assembled from patterns rather than pulled from a life.

A worksheet can only give back what the writer is already thinking, dressed differently. A question can go looking in places the writer forgot they were carrying.

STRATUM

It's about where a writer's material actually lives — not in a prompt, and not in a worksheet, but somewhere in the writer's own experience. A question is the only tool built to retrieve it.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

You are carrying more about your characters than you've written down. That's the premise this entire course is built on. The scene that's currently flat on your page isn't flat because the material is missing. It's flat because nobody has asked you the question that brings it to the surface.

You already have a Stefan. More than one, probably. The rest of this course is how you find out which question goes looking for him.